

Editorial

Open Challenge

THINGS HAVE BEEN going almost too well for Microsoft over the past decade. The company couldn't ask for more than what the world has given them: trust, respect, and the power to overwhelmingly dominate their computing experience.

When one entity enjoys such supremacy—even while there are others who can provide what that entity does—the status quo cannot be maintained too long. We keep seeing signs of change, but last month we saw a bit more than usual—many companies, and even the courts of the European Union, aiming straight for Microsoft's jugular.

A day after EU courts rejected Microsoft's appeal in an anti-trust case against them, Google announced its free collaborative presentation application. Presentations is clearly a PowerPoint alternative.

Then came the news that IBM had launched a free personal productivity application suite called Lotus Symphony, based on the open source OpenOffice.org. It supports the Open Document Format, of which IBM has been one of the leading supporters. Free productivity suites have been offered for years as an alternative to MS Office, though with little success—despite the support of major players such as IBM and Sun.

Then, Yahoo! paid \$350 million for Zimbra, a startup that developed a Web-based e-mail and collaboration package comparable with Microsoft Exchange and Outlook.

The Zoho online suite is already making headway in establishing its own online office suite, and is backed by some strong technology.

We've already witnessed the onslaughts on Windows as the *de facto* OS courtesy Linux et al. We're now seeing Office being challenged.

But don't expect Microsoft to lose out any time soon. IDC (International Data Corporation) reports that the market share of MS Office stands at about 95 per cent. Now 95 per cent is not something you can break in one day—or even in one year.

Still the major competitors do all keep trying; more will follow. But think about the power of habit. This issue seems to me like the challenging of your brand of toothpaste. You just don't easily switch! And as humans, even a slight change appears to us as an uphill climb. MS applications have come to mean convenience and comfort, and that creates loyalty.



Deepak Ajwani Executive Editor

“The Indians and the Chinese—who are so value-driven—might give the free apps a chance”

To break the habit in India is even more difficult. For many, the steep prices Microsoft commands is hardly a deterrent—they get the best MS software for pocket change, thanks to piracy.

Now if the competition is trying to take you online, the logical step is that sooner than later, Microsoft will shift its office suite online—and the pay-to-use business model will force you to fork out money for your software. And that's when Indians (and the Chinese)—who are so value-driven—might give the free apps a chance. It's *that* possibility Microsoft needs to be prepared for. When paid online office suites become *de rigueur*, populations growing by the millions each year might swing to the movement of all things open. That *should* make Microsoft uncomfortable.

Stay tuned.

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'D. Ajwani'.

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